Starting Dad's Records File: Three First Moves for a Quiet Week

Three moves, in order, and what can wait.

Dad is managing fine and nobody is applying for anything. You've heard that a Medicaid application can ask for a long history of records, and you couldn't say where half of his paperwork is.

There's time, so start small. Three things, in this order.

1 Learn the general shape of an application

Read one plain description of how applying works, so the word stops being a blank. In general terms, the federal Administration for Community Living describes two parts: filling out an application form, and providing documentation to verify general and financial requirements. States run the program day to day and take the applications, so the details belong to Dad's state. [1]

WHY IT'S ON THE SHORT LIST A file is easier to build once you know what it would be used for.

2 Choose one place for Dad's statements, and start keeping them

With Dad, pick a drawer, a file box or a folder on his computer, and put the statements that arrive from here on into it: bank, investment, retirement, Social Security. For anything he gets online, note which accounts those are and how he gets to the statements. How long to keep them is a question for your Medicaid planner; until you've asked, keep what arrives. [2] [3]

WHY IT'S ON THE SHORT LIST Statements are the one part of the file that arrives a piece at a time, so the habit matters more than the catching up.

3 Start a question list, with the timing question at the top

Write this down first: “What circumstances would tell our family it's time to apply?” Then add every other question as it comes up. The Administration for Community Living says the best time to apply depends on a person's medical situation, marital status and the complexity of their finances, which is why this one gets worked out with your Medicaid planner and not at the kitchen table. [1]

WHY IT'S ON THE SHORT LIST It's the question families most want settled, and the family's part of it is to write it down. A written question gets asked.

What can wait

- Tracking down every old statement. The file starts with what arrives from here on.
- The other categories: insurance, property, and trust or annuity papers if Dad has them. Each gets its turn.
- Which Medicaid program might fit Dad, and how far back records need to go in his state. Those go on the question list.
- Whether or when to apply. Nobody is deciding that this week.
- Any change to an account, a policy or a property. Nothing in this guide calls for one.

Before you open a drawer

Ask Dad. It's his paperwork, and this is a file to build with him. A good opening is the plain one: you'd like to know where things are kept, and you aren't taking anything over.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say which records Dad's state requires, how far back they need to go, or whether or when anyone should apply. It puts a first week in order. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've read how an application works in general, chosen one place for Dad's statements and started your list of questions. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The two parts of an application and the point about timing follow the federal Administration for Community Living. Keeping statements available and papers in one place follows the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau and the National Institute on Aging. The order is ours.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid
2. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
3. National Institute on Aging, Getting Your Affairs in Order Checklist: Documents to Prepare for the Future